

MEMORY LAPSE

The yesteryear heroine shows little acumen in denying romances with co-stars and taking on politicians



BONDING: A MEMOIR

by VYJAYANTIMALA BALI
Stellar

Price: Rs 695

Pages: 410

■ By Sadanand Menon

Vyjayantimala Bali goes ballistic. In her heyday, she took your breath away with her precocious talent in screen histrionics and Bharatanatyam. Now she takes your breath away with her malapropisms. On late husband Dr Chaman Bali: "He was far too progressive for a Punjabi." Or, "I was grandmother Yagamma's dearest pet. That is why we never had any pets at home." Or, regarding rumours of a royal drop in her Iyengar gene pool, "We had no improper connection with the Mysore royalty. It was totally fabricated and distorted with absolutely no truth in it. I am my father's daughter." Isn't there something called editorial intervention in publishing houses? Jyoti Sabharwal, the collaborator, has much to answer for.

Though the gau-cherie keeps multiplying, the current focus on the book has been with respect to references to her *Sangam* co-star, Raj Kapoor. Vyjayantimala does well to pooh-pooh decades of innuendo regarding an alpine alchemy between her and the blue-eyed boy of the Indian screen as a canny strategy devised by the PR men at RK Studios to promote the film. This is how all such suggestive slander should be dealt with.

She even explains that it was necessary for the RK camp to indulge in this sensational ploy in order to sever the connection in the public mind between her and 'tragedy king' Dilip Kumar, with whom she was paired in

at least five major hits in as many years — *Devdas*, *Naya Daur*, *Madhumati*, *Paigam* and the mercurial *Ganga Jamuna*. In 1964, when *Sangam* was released, she was simultaneously working with Kumar in *Leader*. *Sangam*, perhaps, needed the noisily planted whiff of a naughty, off-screen star romance to fill the tills.

But, instead of dropping the story there, Vyjayantimala goes on to call RK a "lady's man", possessed of a "glad eye" and a flirt. Yet, when RK, seeking her consent to act in the film, sent her an openly seductive telegram, "*Bol Radha bol, sangam hoga ki nahin?*" her telegraphic response was an equally flirty "*Sangam hoga, hoga, zaroor hoga*". This exchange went on to

censorship. In the political arena, after some vitriolic attacks on the Tamil Nadu Congress Committee and institutions like the ICCR and the Department of Culture, she takes P.V. Narasimha Rao to the cleaners for his "indifference and disdainful and cavalier behaviour".

By turns, she sounds vain, ingenuous, peevish, pompous, ranting, vengeful, smug, self-righteous and prone to delivering long homilies. After an out-of-the-blue swipe at Picasso and modern art, she launches into an illiterate tirade against M.F. Husain. "How do you qualify to be a painter if you are so insensitive?" she chides. Despite performing for six decades, her views on dance remain shallow, bordering on the puerile, droning on about some illusory notion of 'tradition'.

Buried deep in the book is a sensational revelation about a message Vyjayantimala carried to Rajiv Gandhi, from Janaki Ramachandran, after MGR's demise in 1988, in which Janaki had said "in so many words that if she was enabled to govern the state just for six months, she would be extremely happy to

hand over the reins (sic) to the Congress". Remains to be seen how politicians in Tamil Nadu will react to the news of this game. The other little cover-up operation she indulges in is to suggest she "passively strayed into the BJP", but was not serious. The book concludes with some flattering, genuflecting noises aimed at Sonia Gandhi. Clearly the political ambitions are alive. But this ill-written book is likely to become the unintended roadblock.

Before *Bonding: A Memoir*, Vyjayantimala was merely surrounded by whispers. Now she's likely to be engulfed by a roar. ■



FILM FLING: Vyjayantimala calls Raj Kapoor a "flirt" with a "glad eye"

become a full-fledged song and, along with *Buddha mil gaya* and *Yeh mera prem patra*, propelled the film to its cult status. It's a flawed narrative and one is left with doubts about the narrator's possible memory lapses.

Though Vyjayantimala had two stints in the Lok Sabha and one in the Rajya Sabha, she shows little political acumen in badmouthing those she dislikes. She's catty about Nargis and Madhubala, hostile about Shammi Kapoor, disillusioned with Kumar, dismissive of Dev Anand and scornful of Vijay Anand's liberal views on